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Water, microplastics don't mix

The materials trigger inflammation linked to disease, death. Now scientists appear to have discovered why

By Michael Hawthorne
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Plain old water could be responsible for making plastics harmful to people, according to a new study that portends significant consequences for human health.

The study, published Thursday in the prominent scientific journal Nature, found chemical reactions between water and six types of fossil fuel-based plastic created particles that damaged red blood cells and proteins in laboratory tests.

As plastic in the body breaks down into smaller and smaller bits — known as microplastics and nanoplastics — the potential danger increases, said Wei Min, a Columbia University chemist who co-authored the study.

"Is this phenomenon 5% responsible or 90% responsible for the health effects we are seeing, I can't answer," Min said during an interview. "But I would be surprised if it doesn't play any role."

Min's study comes amid increasing concerns about plastic pollution in the Great Lakes, the source of drinking water for 40 million people in the United States and Canada, including nearly 7 million in the Chicago area.

The Chicago Tribune is documenting the hazards in "Great Waste in the Great Lakes," a series about plastic pollution threatening the health and environment of Americans and Canadians who depend on the world's largest source of fresh surface water.

Interactions between water and plastic could help explain why other studies have shown microplastics trigger inflammation, which contributes to a variety of diseases that together account for more than half of all deaths globally.

For now it's impossible to prevent these reactions within the body. Human blood is about 50% water and cells are up to 80% water, Min noted.

"This challenges the reigning theory that plastic is inert (meaning it doesn't prompt chemical or biological reactions)," said Sherri "Sam" Mason, a chemist at Gannon University in Erie, Pennsylvania, who studies plastic pollution in freshwater.

"I think it highlights the need for truly biodegradable plastic, rather than what industry increasingly puts out into the marketplace," said Mason, who wasn't involved in the new study but was one of the first researchers to find microplastics

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A Serve Robotics delivery robot is parked in the 2300 block of North Kenmore Avenue on the DePaul University campus in Chicago on May 19.
JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Data on the menu?

Two class-action lawsuits allege food delivery robots scan faces and hands of customers, using biometric data to train AI models and share data with third parties. Companies deny the claims

By Jane Miller
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Food delivery robots have become a constant in some parts of Chicago, where they are frequently seen wobbling down sidewalks with takeout orders. But two recently filed lawsuits allege that the robots are also collecting information on their travels.

Class-action lawsuits filed last week against food delivery robot companies Coco and Serve allege that the robot services scan the faces and hands of customers without their consent, using the biometric data to train the companies' own AI models, and sharing the data with third parties. Both Serve and Coco Robotics deny the claims.

"A person's biometric information is a core part of who they are," wrote David Almeida and Lucas Coughlin, the counsel for both plaintiffs, in a joint statement. "Now that advanced AI systems allow companies to identify and track individuals solely by their biometric features, the risks of losing control of this data are greater than ever."

According to the complaints filed in the Circuit Court of Cook County, the extraction of biometric data from both users of the food delivery services and people the robots encounter on their path violates the Illinois Biometric Information Privacy Act.

Enacted by the Illinois General Assembly in 2008, the act defines a biometric identifier as a retina or iris scan, a fingerprint, voiceprint, or a scan of hand or face geometry. The act requires that third parties inform individuals that they are being recorded and allow them to decide whether their biometric identifiers should be recorded, transmitted and used.

Mitchell Breidinger, who lives on the Near North Side, filed the lawsuit against Coco Robotics, and Barry Schain, who lives in Lincoln Park, filed the lawsuit against Serve Robotics. Both Breidinger and Schain allege that their biometric data was recorded by the delivery robot services and transmitted elsewhere without their consent, according to the complaints.

Breidinger is a DoorDash customer who received an order

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Fired FBI workers sue to regain jobs

Employees assigned to Trump's classified documents inquiry

By Eric Tucker
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — FBI employees fired for their roles in the investigation of President Donald Trump's retention of classified documents at his Florida estate sued Thursday to get their jobs back, calling their terminations unlawful acts of "political retribution."

The complaint adds to the growing list of legal challenges to the mass terminations under FBI Director Kash Patel of agents who participated in investigations of the Republican president or are seen as opposed to Trump administration interests.

The lawsuit was filed in federal court in Washington on behalf of nine agents, intelligence analysts and staff operations specialists who were fired in February following earlier dismissals of agents who had worked on the investigation into Trump's efforts to overturn his 2020 presidential election loss to Democrat Joe Biden.

Patel has said in congressional testimony that employees he has fired had "weaponized" the FBI. But the agents deny that claim in the lawsuit, noting that between them they had more than a century of distinguished and apolitical FBI service that involved responding to the Boston Marathon bombing, hostage recoveries and the investigation into the 2024 assassination attempt of Trump in Butler, Pennsylvania.

Their firings, the lawsuit says, create an "immeasurable loss" to "America's national security."

"In return for their service, they were fired because they did their jobs, as they always did to follow the

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ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE


JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Police Detective Juan Ignacio Gonzalez, left, and Alexander Angeles, 18, are candidates for the Chicago school board's District 8B seat.

ELECTION 2026 CHICAGO SCHOOL BOARD

In Southwest Side race, it's teen vs. detective

By Kate Armanini
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Eighteen-year-old Alexander Angeles graduated just a few months ago from Hancock High School. Now a college student, he works part-time at O'Reilly Auto Parts and picks up night shifts at McDonald's.

He wants to be U.S. president someday. For now, he'll settle for a (slightly) lower office: a seat on the Chicago school board, as a write-in candidate.

It's a quixotic campaign in an uncontested Southwest Side district, and the odds, Angeles acknowledged, are slim. But he said he firmly believes students should have a place on the governing body overseeing the nation's third-largest school district — and voters should have more than one choice.

"My goal is to win. I want to win. But I feel like it's bigger than this," said Angeles, running in District 8B, which stretches southwest from the Loop to Chicago Lawn.

The teen faces an improbable, if not impossible, path to victory. As a write-in candidate, he must not only win voters' support and but also persuade them to remember and write his full name on the November ballot. But Angeles, ever-optimistic, isn't deterred by his odds.

His opponent is police detective Juan Ignacio Gonzalez. Gonzalez is also a Marine Corps veteran and the founder of DreamCatcher Café, a coffee shop and community space in Back of the Yards.

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'I actually prefer Chicago than New York'

JPMorgan Chase chairman and CEO Jamie Dimon retraces his Chicago roots at the Economic Club and with a renovated Chase Tower tour. **Business**

Making a happy return

Northwestern quarterback Aidan Chiles says he's confident and having fun again as he prepares to face Michigan State, his former team. **Sports**



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